Brace for ETS on long-haul flights

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with TOMMASO LECCA and JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — The European C

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

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SNEAK PEEK

— The European Commission is moving toward extending the Emissions Trading System to international flights, according to an internal presentation seen by POLITICO a week before the review is due to be unveiled.

— Brussels wants transport to do more of the heavy lifting in cutting Europe's fossil fuel dependence, as a draft of the Electrification Action Plan aims for accelerated EV uptake, charging infrastructure and electric trucks.

— The European Commission is planning to make "Buy European" easier in rail procurement, outlining new powers to close strategic tenders to certain foreign suppliers.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us@tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

COMMISSION NEARS DECISION TO EXTEND ETS TO LONG-HAUL FLIGHTS: The European Commission has come out in favor of "expand[ing] coverage of [the Emissions Trading System] aviation to EU's fair share of emissions from international voyages," according to an internal presentation seen by POLITICO. Such a move would be accompanied by "supporting multilateralism by recognising [the U.N.'s] CORSIA offsetting costs through ETS reduction" while also "addressing the unlevel playing field for EU airlines."

Disclaimer: The document is a recent Commission presentation outlining the current state of the ETS review, due to be unveiled on July 17, and makes clear that it is not the final product. It explicitly states that it "is not an official Commission position," even though it was prepared by the climate department, or DG CLIMA, overseeing the review. "We have no further comment to make," a Commission spokesperson said in response to our request.

Why it matters: With just a week to go before the Commission unveils the ETS review, the presentation strongly suggests that DG CLIMA intends to propose extending the EU's carbon pricing system beyond flights within the EU to cover the bloc's share of emissions from international aviation. Exactly how such a system would interact with CORSIA, however, remains unresolved.

No choice: "There is a legal obligation for us to expand the scope of [ETS] aviation," an EU official told a group of reporters earlier this week. "Obviously, we fully realize that this is easier said than done," the official added, noting that the Berlaymont is still assessing "options for an expansion that does still privilege multilateral initiatives like CORSIA."

Renewed ambition: Meanwhile, in a letter to the Commission seen by Tommaso, three Renew Europe MEPs urged the Berlaymont to "follow through on previous commitments and agreements reached between the co-legislators regarding the extension of the scope of the ETS system, notably for maritime and aviation sectors."

Cash for clean fuels: The letter, signed by centrist MEPs Emma Wiesner, Gerben-Jan Gerbrandy and Pascal Canfin, also calls for the use of "free allowances conditional on investment into decarbonisation." That aligns with DG CLIMA's intention to couple any ETS extension to international flights "with a X fold ramp-up of support for (EU-refined) sustainable aviation fuels," according to the presentation.

Parliament divided: Positions taken by political groups so far point to a split in the Parliament over extending carbon pricing to extra-EU aviation emissions. The European People's Party has defended the current scope of the ETS, in line with the main aviation industry associations, while the Socialists & Democrats support extending the system to international flights.

Greens on board: The Greens are also aligned with the S&D and Renew groups, calling on the Commission "to extend the ETS to all departing international flights" and for private jet flights to be "fully covered" by the legislation, according to another letter to the Commission, signed by the MEPs Terry Reintke, Sara Matthieu, Michael Bloss and Lena Schilling.

CARS AND TRUCKS

COMMISSION PLUGS IN TRANSPORT TO WEAN EUROPE OFF OIL: Brussels wants transport to do more of the heavy lifting in cutting Europe's fossil fuel dependence, with plans to accelerate EV uptake, charging infrastructure and electric trucks, according to a draft of the Electrification Action Plan obtained by POLITICO.

More carrots: By the end of 2026, the Commission will issue recommendations on fiscal and non-fiscal demand-side incentives for zero-emission vehicles, while encouraging governments to use ETS revenues and the Social Climate Fund to support EVs through subsidies, social leasing and tax breaks.

Public fleets next: Brussels will also review the Clean Vehicles Directive by the end of 2027 to consider tightening zero-emission vehicle targets in public procurement, adding to its broader push to drive demand through corporate and public fleets.

Charging ahead: A review of the Alternative Fuels Infrastructure Regulation next year will look at speeding up charging deployment, particularly for electric heavy-duty trucks. The Commission is also launching vehicle-to-grid regulatory sandboxes, with plans to make smart charging the default and require new EVs to be capable of bidirectional charging by the end of 2027.

Ports and planes: Aviation and shipping also feature prominently. The Commission wants electrification to receive support under the ETS-backed Sustainable Aviation Fuels, or SAF scheme for aviation and the Sustainable Maritime Propulsion Mechanism, while signaling a possible extension of the EU ETS to “more maritime transport.” It also wants ports to become energy hubs through greater deployment of shore-side electricity, high-power charging infrastructure and more transparent pricing for onshore power services.

EU HITS CHINESE TIRE IMPORTS: The Commission has imposed definitive anti-dumping duties of between 4.3 percent and 45.3 percent on imports of passenger car and light lorry tyres from China, concluding that Chinese producers were selling into the EU at unfairly low prices and harming European manufacturers.

The numbers: The investigation covers a broad range of pneumatic rubber tyres with a load index below 121. In 2024, the EU consumed around 330 million tyres worth more than €18 billion, with Chinese imports accounting for 93 million units—or 28 percent of the market—valued at more than €2.5 billion.

Why it matters: Brussels says the dumped imports have injured an EU tyre industry that employs more than 80,000 people across 14 member countries. The move follows months of investigation under the bloc’s trade defense rules.

Still to come: The anti-dumping case is only half the story. A parallel anti-subsidy investigation into Chinese tire manufacturers is still underway, with the Commission expected to decide by December whether additional countervailing duties are warranted.

RAIL

‘BUY EUROPE’ PUSH REACHES RAIL PROCUREMENT: The Commission wants public procurement to become a strategic industrial policy tool, proposing a single EU procurement rulebook that would make “European preference” easier to apply and explicitly flag rail rolling stock as a sector where Brussels could close procurement to certain foreign suppliers, according to a draft of the forthcoming Public Procurement Act obtained by POLITICO.

Rail in the spotlight: The draft singles out rail rolling stock alongside shipbuilding as strategically important sectors because of their role in military mobility and Europe’s industrial base. It says that “the Commission should therefore have the power, by means of delegated acts, to close specific procurements to non-covered economic operators or non-covered goods, services or works,” allowing Brussels to shut certain foreign suppliers out of future tenders.

European preference: Contracting authorities would be allowed to favor EU and treaty-covered suppliers by restricting participation, requiring minimum European content or awarding evaluation bonuses to bids with higher EU content. The Commission could also make those preferences mandatory in specific sectors where it considers the bloc’s strategic interests require it.

Transport utilities stay covered: Procurement by entities operating in transport, alongside energy, water and postal services, remains within the EU procurement framework, but the draft adds that these utilities “may also be exempt where the relevant activity is directly exposed to competition on markets with unrestricted access.”

Strategic buying: Public buyers would also have to move beyond the lowest-price model. The Commission wants contracts awarded on the basis of the best price-quality ratio as the default, with greater weight given to resilience, security of supply, innovation and environmental performance.

MARITIME

UKRAINE CLAIMS STRIKE ON RUSSIA'S SHADOW FLEET: Ukraine says it struck 14 vessels linked to Russia's shadow fleet in the Sea of Azov within 24 hours, our colleague Veronika Melkozerova reports, targeting ships Kyiv says were used to supply fuel to the Russian military and transport oil in circumvention of Western sanctions.

The targets: According to the Ukrainian General Staff, the attack hit 12 oil tankers, one tugboat and one dry cargo vessel. The Ukrainian army said the ships were used both to supply fuel to Russian forces and to transport Russian oil abroad, generating revenue for the Kremlin while circumventing international sanctions.

PIT STOPS

Volkswagen's board met Thursday to discuss deeper cost cuts, as an internal paper seen by German tabloid BILD (like POLITICO, part of the Axel Springer group) suggests the carmaker is weighing up to 120,000 job cuts — around 20,000 more than previously reported.

World Cup rivalry has reached cruising altitude, our colleague Sonja Rijnen reports, with Brussels Airlines flying its football-themed "Trident" aircraft to Spain ahead of tonight's Belgium-Spain quarter-final — a playful gesture the carrier says "speaks for itself."

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Trump decides against tariffs on aircraft and parts
By Daniel Desrochers · Jul 10, 2026, 06:04 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Document: EU plans electrification target, but no sign of cooling strategy
By Elena Giordano, Nicolas Camut · Jul 09, 2026, 12:19 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Document: Brussels wants public contracts to prioritize quality over price
The draft Public Procurement Act would make best value the default while strengthening "Buy European" rules.
By Aude van den Hove, Sebastian Starcevic · Jul 09, 2026, 11:03 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

Mansion House Preview: What to Expect From Rachel Reeves' Defining Speech
Jul 13, 2026, 11:00 AM - 11:45 am

Council Working Party on Land Transport
Jul 14, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Council Working Party on Transport – Intermodal Questions and Networks
Jul 16, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Pro Intelligence Connections
2017/0291(COD) Promotion of clean road transport v…
Discussions within the Council or its preparatory…
2021/0211(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin…
Discussions within the Council or its preparatory…
2021/0223(COD) Deployment of alternative fuels inf…
Final act published in Official Journal